

Tree shrews

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Scandentia
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	20

These small, squirrel-like mammals are not wholly arboreal (they spend much of their time on the ground) and are not true shrews. In fact, they have some features that are associated with primates, such as a large braincase and, in males, testes that descend into a scrotum. Tree shrews lack whiskers and seek prey, such as insects, using well-developed senses of hearing, smell, and vision. Most species have a long, thickly furred tail. Tree shrews inhabit the tropical forests of Southeast Asia.

SEEKING FOOD
Tree shrews are skilful climbers and agile runners. They forage with their hands and pointed snout.



Ptilocercus lowi

Pen-tailed tree shrew



Length 4–5½ in (10–14 cm)
Tail 5–7½ in (13–19 cm)
Weight ⅞–2½ oz (25–60 g)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern



Named for its mainly naked tail with bushy white hairs at the tip, like a bottle-brush or old-fashioned quill pen, this species is grayish brown above and grayish yellow on the underside. It climbs skilfully with its strong, sharp-clawed limbs, using its tail for balance, and rarely descends to the ground. It makes simple nests in hollow trees or on branches and lives in pairs or small groups. Its varied diet includes worms, insects, mice, small birds, lizards, and fruit.

Dendrogale melanura

Bornean smooth-tailed tree shrew



Length 4–6 in (10–15 cm)
Tail 3½–5½ in (9–14 cm)
Weight 1¼–2½ oz (35–60 g)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Data deficient



This species lives in mountain forests at altitudes of 3,000–5,000 ft (900–1,500 m). Its long limbs and long claws equip it to grasp branches and it spends more time in trees than other tree shrews. The coloration of its upperparts is a mixture of black and buff or cinnamon; the underparts and legs are more red or ocher. It lives alone, feeding by day and sleeping in a leaf-lined tree nest at night. After a gestation period of about 50 days, the female produces 3–4 young.

Anathana ellioti

Indian tree shrew



Length 6½–8 in (17–20 cm)
Tail 6½–7½ in (16–19 cm)
Weight 5 oz (150 g)
Location S. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Also known as the Madras tree shrew, this mammal resembles a small, slender gray squirrel. It is speckled with yellow and brown on the upperparts and has a distinctive cream-colored shoulder

stripe. The Indian tree shrew has a prominent head with a pointed muzzle, large eyes, and furred ears. It forages actively by day on the ground and among low bushes, as well as in trees, for small edible items, mainly worms and insects but also some fruit.

At night, it sleeps in a rock crevice or tree-hole. The species is probably solitary outside the breeding season and does not, as far as is known, defend a specific territory, but information is lacking. The female cares for the young.



Tupaia minor

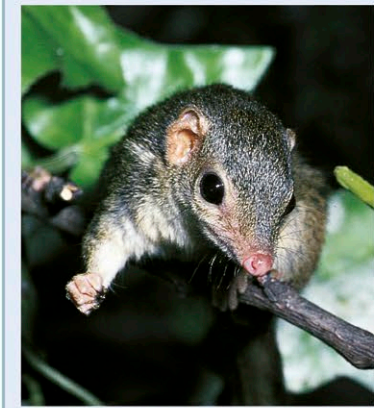
Lesser tree shrew



Length 4¾–5¼ in (11.5–13.5 cm)
Tail 5–6½ in (13–17 cm)
Weight 1⅛–2½ oz (30–70 g)
Location S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This species is more tolerant than most other tree shrews of the loss of natural forest habitat to plantations, parks, and gardens. It is a skilled climber and has a wide diet. It forages by day along branches, in bushes, among fallen logs, and under rocks for small animals, fruit, leaves, seeds, and carrion. Usually 1–3 young are born after a gestation period of 45–55 days. The female leaves the offspring in a leafy nest among the foliage while she feeds, returning sporadically to suckle. Tree shrews fall victim to snakes, mongooses, tree-dwelling cats, and diurnal birds of prey. They often hold food by their front paws while sitting up on their haunches, in the manner of a squirrel, to watch for danger.



GRIPPING FEET

The splayed toes, sharp claws, and pimply protrusions on the foot pads of the lesser tree shrew all give an excellent grip on bark and rock. It uses its front legs to pull itself along branches on its belly. This spreads scent produced by abdominal glands. This scent is likely to be recognizable to others of its species, and is probably a means of marking its home range, which it defends against others of the same sex.

SENSES AND BALANCE

The lesser tree shrew's prominent nose, eyes, and ears ensure keen senses; the long tail helps with balance while climbing at speed through the branches.

speckled olive-brown or red fur on upperparts

